

Embarrassment OF RICHES

The latest grist for the political opponents of Shashi Tharoor, Congress candidate for the Thiruvananthapuram Lok Sabha seat, is his wealth. Tharoor, with assets of over Rs 21 crore, is the richest candidate ever in Kerala. As per his affidavit, Tharoor has assets worth Rs 14.41 crore while his wife Christa Giles has wealth totalling Rs 4.80 crore. As expected, Tharoor, 53, who has spent most of his life abroad, including 30 years working in

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the UN, has most of his assets and investments in foreign countries. Tharoor and his wife's assets include Rs 15 crore as bank savings, debentures and shares, a Rs 1.10-crore house in Canada; a Rs 24.98-lakh apartment in Ernakulam, ancestral property worth Rs 2.5 lakh in Palakkad. Tharoor, chairman of the Dubai-based Afras Ventures, has Rs 12,000 in hand and neither he nor his wife own any vehicle or gold. *by M.G. Radhakrishnan*

THE CLEAN MOVEMENT

Looks like it's getting time to make a clean break from our not-so-clean electoral past. What makes E-2009 different—apart from the usual political rhetoric—is another voice that is making itself heard, that of the ordinary citizen. From retired chief justices, young professionals and even Bollywood stars, a pan-Indian movement has begun against criminalisation of politics. Retired Chief Justice J.S. Verma recently issued an appeal asking parties to desist from giving tickets to tainted politicians. "We are no longer prepared to tolerate law-breakers masquerading as law-makers," he said.

Equally active is the Association of Democratic Reforms (ADR), an organisation set up by the professors of the Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad, with the help of young graduates and which scans affidavits filed by candidates. Of the 730 candidates declared so far, it has come up with a list of 63 nominees with criminal backgrounds. To bring in the glam element, it has roped in Bollywood star Aamir Khan. "There is an old adage in management courses that if you put the right people in the right place then the job will be done," says Anil Bairwal, national coordinator, ADR. His team analyses the affidavits filed by the candidates and releases the information to the public. According to their data, the current Lok Sabha has 128 MPs who have criminal backgrounds with 333 cases of heinous crimes such as rape, murder and kidnapping registered against them. A Bangalore-based NGO Janaagraha has tied up with Tata Tea to come up with the popular campaign 'Jaago Re', that asks voters not just to wake up but also 'awaken'. "We have designed the first of its kind online registration form to get first-time voters. In six months we have reached out to half-a-million people," says Janaagraha's Suman R.

Bollywood too has its own venture. Artiste and Congress MP Milind Deora's brother Mukul Deora, along with Karan Johar and Imran Khan, has conceptualised and produced a short film exhorting the public to vote in the change they want to bring. The trio have roped in young Bollywood actors to star in the film. "The youth have realised that they are not the future but the present. They can bring in the change they want by voting for the right people," says Mukul. The working title of the film is 'Aap ke Haath Mein' (in your hands). Which just about sums up this movement.

by Priya Sahgal

CITIZENS' INITIATIVES

YASBANT NEGI



JUSTICE VERMA IS AGAINST CRIMINALS IN POLITICS